

600–610



A coin depicting the Eastern Roman emperor Heraclius.

UPHEAVAL IN THE EASTERN ROMAN EMPIRE

began when the emperor Maurice (r. 582–602) dispatched his armies to the northern Balkans to regain imperial control of the Danube frontier from the Avars (see 568–88). In 602, the army rebelled under officer Phocas and Maurice was killed. **Phocas became emperor** but **Chosroes II** of Sasanian Persia **took advantage** of the eastern empire's weakness, while the Avars invaded from the north. In 610 the son of the military governor of Roman Africa, **Heraclius**, executed Phocas and declared himself emperor.

In 606, in northern India, Harsha (c. 590–647) acceded to the thrones of Thanesar and Kannauj, establishing the **last native Indian empire** of ancient times.

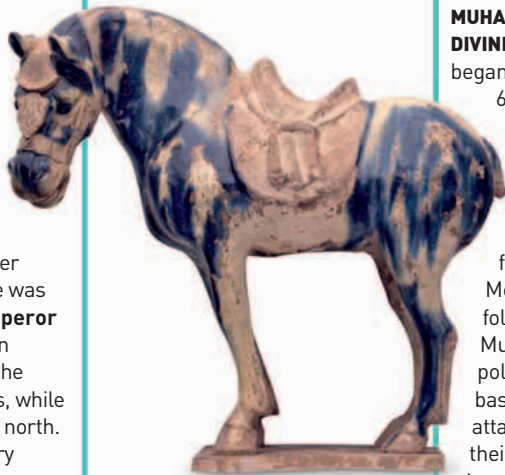
“THE EMPEROR HARSHA, NOBLE IN BIRTH AND OF WELL-CHOSEN NAME, THE SURPASSER OF ALL THE VICTORIES WON BY ALL THE KINGS OF ANCIENT TIMES...”

Banabhatta, Indian poet, from *The Deeds of Harsha*, c. 640

611–620



A Tang dynasty Mendicant friar, with an unusual traveling companion.



Tang dynasty horse sculpture
Horses were symbols of military prowess, especially warhorses from the western fringes of the empire.

SASANIAN CONQUESTS RESTORED THE PERSIAN EMPIRE at the expense of the **Byzantines** with the falls of Jerusalem in 614 and Egypt in 619. By 618, Constantinople was besieged by the Avars, and their Slavic subjects. In 620, Heraclius bought off the Avars in order to focus on repelling the Persians.

In 613 **Clothar II** (584–629) **reunited the Frankish kingdom**, bringing an end to civil war. His Edict of Paris, issued in 614, introduced reforms to the Merovingian church and state.

In 616–17, rebellions against the despotic rule of Yangdi (r. 604–17) caused the collapse of the Sui dynasty in China. A year later military governor **Li Yuan founded the Tang dynasty**, which ruled until 906.

621–630



This 1721 engraving by Austrian architect Johann Fischer von Erlach shows AL-Haram Mosque and Ka'aba in Mecca.

MUHAMMAD FIRST RECEIVED A DIVINE REVELATION IN 610 and began to preach in Mecca from 613; but the start of the Islamic era is traditionally marked by the Hegira or *hijra*, the **flight to Medina**. Hostility from the Meccan authorities forced Muhammad to flee to Medina with his family and followers in 622. In Medina, Muhammad established a political and religious power base. He fought a series of attacks by Meccan forces, with their ultimate surrender in 630 when he took possession of the Ka'aba, the holiest shrine in the

Arabian Peninsula. Muhammad's rule was then unchallenged.

Heraclius began to claw back territory ceded to the Persians, starting at the Battle of Issus in 622 and later, in 627, at the Battle of Nineveh. In 628 the **Sasanian and Byzantine Empires** made peace, exhausted by decades of war and unaware of the storm brewing to the south.

In China the emperor's son, **Taizong, consolidated Tang power** by suppressing rebellions across the empire. In 626, Taizong forced his father to step down and inaugurated a golden age of trade, prosperity, and cultural exchange.



MUHAMMAD (570–632)

Born in Mecca, Muhammad ibn Abdallah worked as a merchant and shepherd before growing discontented and retiring to a life of contemplation. In 610, he received the first of a series of divine revelations—these became the Qu'ran. He preached a monotheistic faith based on complete submission to God (Islam). Before his death he unified Arabian tribes within his new religion.

631–640



The ruins of the 7th century Byzantine fortresses at Sbeitla, Tunisia.

BY THE TIME OF MUHAMMAD'S DEATH IN 632, the young Muslim community—united by Islam, which transcended traditional rivalries—was ready for expansion. Although Muhammad had left no guidance as to his successor (caliph), four men tied to the prophet by marriage emerged as

“THOSE WHO ARE PATIENT IN ADVERSITY AND FORGIVE WRONGS ARE THE DOERS OF EXCELLENCE.”

Prophet Muhammad

the Rashidun, or “rightly guided,” caliphs. **The first caliph, Abu Bakr** (r. 632–34), suppressed an Arabian rebellion, reestablished Islamic dominion over Arabia, and began the conquest of Syria. His successor **Umar** (r. 634–44) **became caliph** in 634 and oversaw the conquest of **Syria** and the defeat of the Byzantines at Ajnadayn. By 637, Umar controlled Jerusalem and Damascus, and, in the same year, Arab forces conquered **Persia** (modern Iran and Iraq), occupying the Sasanian capital at Ctesiphon. **Umar established several important practices**: the creation of garrison towns in conquered territory to separate the invading Arabic forces from the locals; the recruitment of soldiers through slavery and tribal

602 Eastern Roman emperor Maurice killed; Phocas succeeds him
606 Harsha begins conquest of northern India
602 Emperor Yangdi orders construction of Grand Canal; completed 610
610 Heraclius becomes Eastern Roman Emperor

613 Clothar II reunites Frankish kingdom
613 Muhammad starts preaching in Mecca
618 Sui Emperor Yangdi murdered; Tang dynasty established
619 Persians conquer Egypt

622 Battle of Issus, first in a string of victories for Heraclius over Persians
624 Northern China subdued by Tang
626 Tang Emperor overthrown by his son, Taizong
629 Dagobert succeeds Clothar II as king of all the Franks

628 Sasanian king Chosroes II “the victorious” deposed and slain by his son
630 Heraclius reaches zenith of his power and fame by marching triumphantly into Jerusalem
630 Xuanzang reaches India on his epic journey to the west

632 Death of the prophet Muhammad; start of caliphate
635 Nestorian Christians reach China
634 Death of caliph Abu Bakr; Umar becomes second caliph